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ARTICLE

Israel Divided: The Messiah, The Temple And The Future

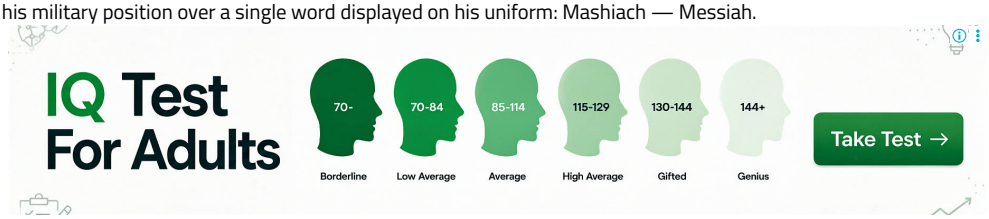


BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 13, 2026

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An Israeli soldier lost his military position over a single word displayed on his uniform: Mashiach — Messiah.



According to Religious Zionist lawmaker Ohad Tal, the soldier was a highly trained anti-drone specialist whose commanders ordered him to remove a patch bearing the Hebrew word for Messiah. He complied, but was nevertheless removed from his position and barred from reserve service.

The account, shared by Tal at a recent political gathering in Jerusalem, has become a symbol of a much larger struggle unfolding inside Israel.

How can a nation established as the Jewish homeland find itself divided over expressions of Jewish faith? And what does it mean to be a Jewish state when its citizens disagree so profoundly about God, the Messiah, biblical territory, and even the future of Jerusalem?

As Israelis prepare for national elections on October 27, these questions are moving from religious debates into the political arena.

For Christians watching Israel through the lens of biblical prophecy, the divisions reveal something remarkable: the Jewish people have returned to their ancient homeland, but they remain deeply divided over what that restoration actually means.



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One Nation, Radically Different Visions

From the outside, Israel is often portrayed as a united Jewish nation confronting hostile enemies. The reality is considerably more complicated.

In secular Tel Aviv, many Israelis embrace Western lifestyles, support democratic institutions, and oppose religious authorities dictating public policy. Jewish identity may be deeply important to them culturally and nationally without requiring strict religious observance.

Elsewhere, Religious Zionist communities see the modern state as part of God's unfolding plan for the Jewish people. For many, settling the biblical heartland of Judea and Samaria is not merely a political preference but a religious responsibility.

Then there are the ultra-Orthodox, or Haredi, communities, including numerous Hasidic groups, whose lives revolve around Torah study, religious law, distinctive customs, and tightly connected communities.

Some Haredi groups participate actively in Israeli politics. Others remain deeply suspicious of secular Zionism, and a small minority reject the legitimacy of a Jewish state established before the Messiah's arrival.

These divisions cannot be reduced to religious versus nonreligious. Many Israelis fall somewhere between these categories, and disagreements within religious communities can be just as intense as those between religious and secular Jews.

Even the meaning of the Messiah is contested.

Some Religious Zionists regard the establishment of Israel as an important stage in national redemption. Other Orthodox Jews believe redemption must unfold through divine intervention rather than political activism.

Christians, of course, hold a fundamentally different conviction: that Jesus is the promised Messiah and that His return will fulfill God's remaining promises.



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The Ultra-Orthodox Question: Who Must Defend Israel?

Perhaps nowhere are these divisions more explosive than in the Israeli military.

For decades, many ultra-Orthodox men studying in religious institutions received military exemptions or deferments. Their communities have defended Torah study as an essential contribution to the spiritual survival of the Jewish people.

But as Israeli soldiers have fought prolonged wars, the arrangement has become increasingly controversial.

Families whose sons serve in dangerous combat units ask why other young men can remain in religious schools while their own children risk their lives.

Religious Zionist Jews, many of whom serve enthusiastically in the military, frequently share that frustration. Their understanding of faith includes defending the land through military service.

The dispute has reached Israel's highest courts, which have ruled against broad exemptions lacking a legal foundation. Attempts to protect draft-eligible religious students from enforcement have generated further legal and political battles.

Military service is only part of the controversy.

Ultra-Orthodox communities often maintain separate educational systems, distinctive standards of dress, religious restrictions on technology and entertainment, and traditional expectations surrounding family life.

Questions surrounding employment, government funding, education, and integration into broader Israeli society have become major political issues.

The result is an extraordinary contradiction: some of Israel's most religious citizens remain among the least integrated into the institutions of the modern Jewish state.

The Third Temple: Even Religious Jews Disagree

For Christians interested in Bible prophecy, another division is especially significant.

The movement to rebuild the Jewish Temple in Jerusalem is no longer merely a subject of historical speculation.

Organizations such as the Temple Institute have spent years preparing vessels, priestly garments, and educational materials associated with renewed Temple worship.

Some Jewish activists advocate expanded Jewish prayer rights on the Temple Mount, where the First and Second Temples once stood and where the Dome of the Rock and Al-Aqsa Mosque now stand.

Others believe rebuilding the Temple represents an essential step toward Israel's spiritual restoration.

Yet these activists do not speak for all religious Jews.

Many Orthodox authorities have traditionally prohibited Jews from entering portions or all of the Temple Mount because of concerns about ritual purity and the location of the ancient Temple's holiest areas.

Some religious Jews believe the Temple must be restored through divine intervention or in the messianic age, rather than through modern political initiatives.

Secular Israelis, meanwhile, may regard attempts to change the Temple Mount's religious arrangements as dangerous provocations capable of igniting another regional conflict.

The irony is striking. Jews who pray daily for the restoration of Jerusalem and the Temple can disagree profoundly over whether anyone should attempt to rebuild it today.

For Christians who interpret Daniel 9:27, Matthew 24:15, and 2 Thessalonians 2:4 as pointing toward a future Temple and renewed sacrifices, these developments deserve attention.

The preparations are real. The disagreements are real. But the existence of Temple activists does not mean Israel has reached a national consensus about rebuilding the sanctuary.

The Jews Who Believe The Messiah Has Already Come

Amid these competing visions of Israel is another community that receives far less attention: Jewish Israelis who believe that Jesus — Yeshua — is the promised Messiah.

Known as Messianic Jews, they represent a tiny minority of Israel's population. Estimates vary, with some placing their numbers around 10,000 to 30,000 and others suggesting more. Despite their small numbers, they maintain congregations throughout Israel and an active presence in Israeli society.

Many are deeply patriotic. They speak Hebrew, celebrate Jewish holidays, raise their children in Israel, and serve in the Israel Defense Forces. Some have fought and died defending their country. Their belief in Jesus has not diminished their commitment to the Jewish people or their ancestral homeland.

Yet their faith places them in a unique and sometimes difficult position.

Mainstream Jewish religious authorities generally reject the idea that someone can accept Jesus as divine Messiah while remaining religiously Jewish. Messianic believers can face social rejection, discrimination, and hostility because of their convictions.

Their presence introduces another fascinating dimension to Israel's spiritual identity crisis. While some Jews await the Messiah, others debate whether the modern state is part of His coming, and still others prepare for a future Temple, these Jewish believers proclaim that the Messiah has already come — and that He will return.

For Christians, their existence is a reminder that the story of faith in Jesus began among the Jewish people themselves, and that Jewish followers of Christ remain part of Israel's story today.

Gaza, Judea And Samaria: Who Owns The Biblical Land?

The struggle over Israel's identity becomes even more contentious when the discussion turns to territory.

At a recent Jerusalem election gathering, political activist Moshe Feiglin argued that Israel's military failures cannot be separated from its loss of biblical identity.

In his view, Gaza belongs to the Jewish people because it forms part of the land promised by God.

He advocated conquest, removal of Gaza's Palestinian population, and renewed Jewish settlement.

His remarks drew enthusiastic applause from portions of the audience, but they also illustrated a major divide within Israeli society.

For some religious nationalists, biblical promises establish an enduring Jewish claim to the land, making territorial concessions a betrayal of Israel's inheritance.

Others, including religious Jews who accept those biblical promises, question whether they require immediate political sovereignty over every territory or justify the displacement of existing populations.

Many security-focused Israelis oppose permanent resettlement of Gaza because of the enormous military, diplomatic, and humanitarian consequences.

Similar disagreements surround Judea and Samaria, known internationally as the West Bank, where settlement expansion and proposals for Israeli sovereignty remain fiercely contested.

These are not simply disagreements about borders.

They are competing understandings of whether modern Israel should function primarily as a democratic nation-state, a refuge for the Jewish people, or an instrument for fulfilling biblical promises.

An Election That Could Redefine Israel

On October 27, Israelis are scheduled to elect a new Knesset, potentially reshaping the coalitions that determine the nation's direction.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's political future is under intense scrutiny following the failures surrounding October 7, the prolonged wars, and bitter disagreements over national leadership.

But the election reaches beyond Netanyahu.

Will religious parties gain greater influence over education, military exemptions, and public life? Will the next government accelerate settlement expansion or seek to restrain it? Will pressure grow to alter longstanding arrangements on the Temple Mount?

And will Israel's future be shaped primarily by religious nationalism, secular democratic priorities, or a coalition attempting to reconcile the two?

Israel's Arab citizens also have a stake in these decisions, particularly where debates over national identity, equal citizenship, and territorial policy intersect.

No election can settle every religious disagreement. Nevertheless, the coalition that emerges could influence Israeli society for years.

A Nation Restored — But Spiritually Divided

For students of Bible prophecy, there is something extraordinary about this moment.

After nearly two thousand years without an independent Jewish state, Israel has been reestablished. Hebrew has been revived as a national language. Jewish communities from around the world have returned to their ancestral homeland.

Yet political restoration has not produced spiritual unity.

Ezekiel 36–37 describes both the regathering of Israel and a profound spiritual renewal. Zechariah 12 speaks of Jerusalem becoming a burden to the nations and describes a future outpouring of repentance and mourning.

These passages remind Christians that the restoration of the Jewish people and their ultimate spiritual redemption are related but distinct themes in biblical prophecy.

The modern Jewish state is home to people who eagerly await the Messiah, people who disagree over how redemption will occur, people who have little interest in religious expectations at all, and a small but faithful community of Jewish believers who proclaim that Jesus is the Messiah.

Some dream of rebuilding the Temple. Others believe it must await God's timing. Still others fear the consequences of attempting it.

Some see military service as a sacred duty. Others believe Torah study is their highest obligation.

And while the world focuses on Israel's enemies beyond its borders, Israelis themselves are debating what kind of nation they want to become.

It may also reveal which vision of Israel is gaining influence at a pivotal moment in its history.

Israel has returned to the land. The struggle over its spiritual identity, however, is far from over.

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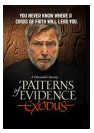
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